

SPACE SHUTTLE

Reusable manned spacecraft

Until the space shuttle programme, manned missions used vehicles that could only be used once. The concept behind the space shuttle was to make flying into space as easy as taking a plane flight. It was launched by rockets, orbited Earth, then flew down to land on a runway. NASA built five space shuttles, but Challenger and Columbia suffered tragic failures that killed their crews. Discovery, Endeavour, and Atlantis continued to ferry astronauts and supplies to the International Space Station (ISS) until the programme was retired in 2011.

Up to eight astronauts
could travel in the
crew cabin

DATA FILE



SIZE: 37 m (121 ft) long



NUMBER OF MISSIONS: 135
(between 1981 and 2011)



SPACE AGENCY: NASA

